

Your task for this assignment is to pick one of the works shown, then look at it carefully and decide if, IN YOUR OPINION, it represents **ART** or **CRAFT**. Write a paragraph that describes your thinking on the piece that answers the following nine questions:

- Is this piece ART or CRAFT? Is it perhaps BOTH?
- What about this selection drew you to it or caught your eye?
- What kinds of *feelings* does the piece elicit when you see it?
- What do you think the artist is trying to say with the piece?
- What does the piece say to YOU personally regardless of what the artist is saying?
- Do you think Artificial Intelligence could produce something of equal meaning?
- How do you think you might apply the concept of art or craft to your software designs and coding?
- Do you think software creation SHOULD BE an art? Should it be a craft?
- What kinds of questions do you ask yourself about your design/code? Do you go back to it after it is working and re-factor it to make it *clean*?

THERE ARE NO WRONG ANSWERS HERE. This is an opinion piece which is intended to get you thinking about YOUR software efforts and how engaged you are with your products, beyond simply making it work.

For this assignment, I decided to take a look at this piece on the left:



I believe especially with physical mediums like sculpture or drawing, art rarely exists without craft. The word “craft”, to me, gets across the idea of the artist having a technique/form that can be seen from the work. Painting is absolutely a part of this. It is both an expression of creativity from the artist, and a physical “work” assembled with some prior technique and form. This piece drew my eye because while a lot of her works in the gallery used reds, yellows and oranges, this piece largely lacks those colors except for a bit of yellow, and is almost exclusively blue.

The piece elicits a calm, quiet sadness. The girl’s expression is mostly blank but seemingly a bit anguished as well. Given the age and pose of the girl and the expression, I believe the artist is also trying to get across a feeling of helplessness. Her hands are folded and placed on her lap, and she appears to be seated, maybe even restrained. To me, it makes me reflect on times in my life when there’s nothing I can do about a situation but wait it out, or bide my time. Knowing about Olabisi’s identity and her life, I made the connection that this piece could be about a young girl growing up during a time of oppressive racism, knowing that at her current age,

there is not yet anything she can do to turn the tides. But perhaps the calmness in her expression and the small yellow speck indicates that she knows one day that she will have an impact.

I strongly believe that Generative AI in a vacuum cannot produce anything with inherent meaning. Although, I believe that eventually, as AI generation tools get better and further enable the user to create more specific art, this will change. But currently as it stands, with the extremely simple input-output creation process, very little of the human prompter's INTENTIONS and STYLE get across into the piece. This is the main problem for me.

I believe that due to purposeful coding's inherent desire for conformity and the fact that creativity never really the end goal, my coding cannot be considered an "art", at least not regarding the projects I currently am working on. In order for that to happen, my end goal cannot solely be efficiency or functionality. However, it is absolutely a craft, requiring a use of technique and training to do properly!

I think coding, like ANY human activity, has the potential to be an art. But just like the difference between painting a street sign and painting a beautiful portrait, intention and end goal makes all the difference. I am always asking myself about proper syntax, technique, and time/space efficiency while coding, so I think it would be extremely interesting to work on a coding project where creativity is the end goal, where I don't need or want to think about the runtime, design patterns, and utility of it. Although as a counter argument to that, I absolutely believe design patterns CAN be beautiful, and creating art that follows a set of rules is absolutely possible and happens all the time...

Thank you for making me think about this, it was a very interesting exercise! I might start a web app purely for the art of it, haha.